secularism is, that permits the perversion of religion. There are no fundamentalists or revivalists in traditional society.'[1]

The implication is that secularism has deprived Indians of their moral underpinnings—the meaning that faith gives to life—and religious extremism has risen as an almost inevitable antithesis to the secular project. The only way out of this dilemma is for Hindus to return to the tolerant, holistic, just, pluralist *dharma* articulated so effectively by Swami Vivekananda, which embraces both worldly and spiritual duty.

After all, as Mr Tampi points out, the Hindu's secular pursuit of material happiness is not meant to be divorced from his obedience to the ethical and religious tenets of his faith. So the distinction between 'religious' and 'secular' is an artificial one: there is no such compartmentalisation in Hinduism. When you conduct your life by performing your duties ethically, are you 'secular' or (since you are fulfilling your *dharma* while adhering to a moral code) a 'good Hindu'?

There is also a terminological issue here. The secularism avowed by successive Indian governments, as Professor R. S. Misra of Banaras Hindu University has argued, is based on *dharma-nirpekshata* ('keeping apart from dharma'), which is impossible for any good Hindu to adhere to. BJP politicians like Rajnath Singh and Yogi Adityanath have argued that Indian governments cannot observe *dharma-nirpekshata* but should follow the precept of *panth-nirpekshata* (not favouring any particular sect or faith). In this they are not far removed from my argument—which I have made for several years before my entry into Indian politics—that 'secularism' is a misnomer in the Indian context of profuse religiosity, and what we should be talking about is 'pluralism'. I believe the roots of India's pluralism can be found in the Hindu acceptance of difference, which has become an article of faith for most of Indian society. But many critics of secularism are not terribly enamoured of pluralism either. To Professor Misra, for instance, the problem with *dharma-nirpekshata* is that an authentically Indian ethic would ensure that secular objectives are infused with *dharma*.

I find this view persuasive but incomplete. Yes, *dharma* is essential in the pursuit of material well-being, public order and good governance, but this should not mean turning public policy over to *sants* and *sadhus*, nor